

‘You seem to have taken offence. I never said I would not invest. I just wanted you to convince me,’ I said.

‘I am not offended, Lala. But I cannot help feeling that you are getting a bit carried away by your success. Else you wouldn’t be lecturing me about valuations,’ GB said, and took a swig at his beer.

The unsaid line here was: ‘ . . . else you wouldn’t be lecturing Bhaiyya on valuations.’

The mug covered much of his face, and for a few seconds I could see only his eyes. They seemed cold, and the piercing look gave me the jitters. I am not saying that he was trying to intimidate me, but that look did unsettle me a bit. I thought I was arguing a business point, but GB interpreted that as a sign of arrogance.

I quickly reached across and rested my palm on his elbow as a reconciliatory gesture.

‘Rest assured it is nothing like that, Govindbhai, you know that I would never refuse you,’ I said.

He smiled – a signal that all was forgiven.

‘Glad to know that success has not changed you at all,’ he said, and we both laughed.

The issue just about sailed through, mainly on support from Rakesh’s friends and business associates who had made good money from his investment tips in the past and were convinced that the Rakesh magic would work for A2Z too. The institutional and retail portions of the book were undersubscribed, while the non-institutional portion was subscribed more than three times, helping make up the shortfall.

Still, the shares had a disastrous debut, opening at a discount and never going above the issue price. Rakesh bought 5 lakh shares in the market at Rs 352 apiece, hoping his purchase would attract fresh buyers and arrest the slide in the stock price. The trade did not hurt him, considering he had sold as many shares in the IPO for Rs 400 each. The stock finally ended the day at Rs 329, a good 18 per cent below the issue price.

Promoter Amit Mittal too jumped into the fray, buying close to 9 lakh shares at Rs 336 each. But both Rakesh’s and Mittal’s purchases only ended up providing an exit to investors looking to jump ship. It was widely expected that the stock would fare poorly on listing. The tepid response from institutions and retail during the bidding process meant there was no demand for the stock. As soon as the shares listed, HNIs who had invested